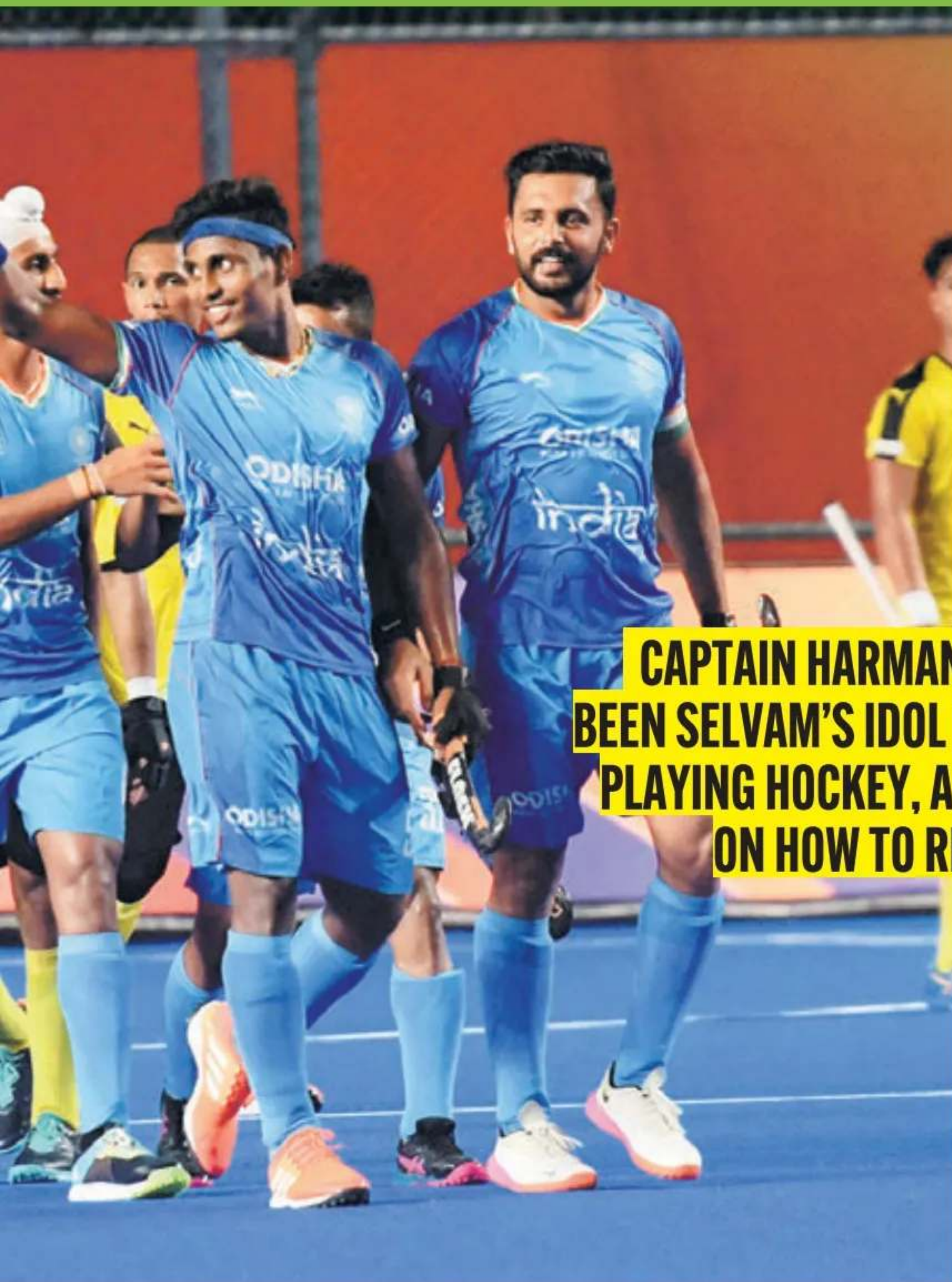




## CAPTAIN HARMANPREET SINGH, WHO HAS BEEN SELVAM'S IDOL EVER SINCE HE STARTED PLAYING HOCKEY, ADVISED THE YOUNGSTER ON HOW TO RECEIVE THE BALL BETTER

new. I have played with them before. Having played in the ACT, my mindset is now different. With my experience, I want to help the TN team do well in the National Games and the Senior National championships (in November in Chennai).

### Can you share your Pro League experience in London, Netherlands and Rourkela?

I enjoyed and learnt from them. The Europeans play fast hockey with quick ball distribution. I felt the urge to compete and improve after playing in the Pro League.

### You must have felt bad on missing the cut for the Hangzhou Asian Games?

I got news of my exclusion after the ACT. I didn't ask any questions. I was told that the seniors were given a chance and that I needed experience and to improve on certain things.

### Such as?

I have to improve inside the 'D' and run better without the ball. I also have to improve my body language while running.

### You must have watched the Indian

### team's Asian Games performance.

Yes. There's a significant difference between the team's performance in the ACT and Hangzhou.

Take, for example, the way we played against Pakistan in Chennai and in the Asian Games. There were stark differences. We had speed and scored plenty in the Asian Games, but we couldn't replicate the same success in the ACT.

I regret missing out on the Games. My focus now is to secure a spot in the national team for the Paris Olympics, where competition for my position will be intense.

### Your father is working as a watchman in a college while your mom is a domestic worker. Given the difficult economic situation, how did you manage your career?

In the early days, I didn't have many people to help me. It's only when I started playing for the national team that people started noticing me.

During difficult times, Ranjit Kumar helped me financially; he still does. My parents are happy now. Of course, it was a tough childhood. Now that I have got a job in the Income Tax Department (Chennai), we are more or less settled.

My younger brother is working and my elder sister is doing well. I am relieved as my parents' struggles have resulted in my dream becoming a reality.

### Your next target?

We have the Pro League coming up, and, sometime in January, we have the 5-on-5 World Cup. I hope to do well in the selection trials and be a part of the team.